

Spatial Distribution of Bidirectional Charging Stations by Simulation and Evaluation of Traffic and Grid Data

Achim BAUMGÄRTNER¹, Erik WEIGAND¹,
Gian Bruno TRUÖL^{1,2}, Mirko SONNTAG^{1,2}

¹University of Applied Sciences Esslingen, Esslingen University, Germany

²Fraunhofer Application Center Keim, Esslingen, Germany

acbait01@hs-esslingen.de, erwewi01@hs-esslingen.de,
gian.ledl-truol@hs-esslingen.de, mirko.sonntag@hs-esslingen.de

Submitted: 01 August 2026 | Revised: 25 March 2026 | Accepted: 01 August 2026

Abstract. This paper's goal is the investigation on how bidirectional charging stations can be distributed across a dynamic area by combining traffic simulation with partially extracted grid data from official sources. We model charging demand as a spatiotemporal process and evaluate candidate locations with respect to accessibility, traffic flow, and waiting time. The proposed workflow integrates mobility traces, station utilization forecasts, and synthetic grid constraints to identify robust deployment strategies. Results indicate that jointly optimizing traffic and grid criteria can reduce peak grid load while improving charging availability in high-demand districts.

Keywords: Bidirectional charging, traffic simulation, SUMO, OpenStreetMap, spatio-temporal analysis, charging demand, V2G

1. Introduction

The rapid growth of electric mobility is shifting charging-infrastructure planning from static placement rules toward data-driven decision support [1]. Bidirectional charging adds a further dimension: vehicles are no longer only energy consumers but can also feed power back, turning charging points into distributed flexibility assets [2]. Deciding where to place such stations therefore requires understanding where and when charging demand actually concentrates.

Because electric vehicles still represent a small share of the fleet, there is little real-world data on where charging stations should be placed and how intensively they are used. At the same time, uncoordinated charging concentrates electrical load in space and time and can stress local distribution grids [3], which makes the spatial and temporal structure of demand a central

planning question. Existing siting studies, however, often rely on data or tooling that is not openly reproducible [4]. We therefore ask: *how can candidate locations for charging stations be ranked from openly available data, based on their accessibility and on how charging demand is distributed over space and time?*

To address this, we build a simulation workflow on openly available data. Road-network and land-use information are taken from OpenStreetMap, and traffic is simulated microscopically in SUMO, controlled through its Python interface TraCI. From land-use points of interest (residential buildings, offices, and amenities) we derive travel demand, and we model charging as a *spatiotemporal* process, that is, demand that varies simultaneously by location and time of day. The model distinguishes public charging stations from private home wallboxes with vehicle-specific access control. A custom web interface lets users select an area of interest on

a map and generate ready-to-run scenarios directly, lowering the barrier to reproducing and extending the analysis. Candidate sites are then assessed in terms of accessibility, station utilization, and the resulting local charging load.

The scope of this study is the planning and evaluation stage. We focus on the spatial and temporal distribution of charging demand and load under realistic mobility patterns; a detailed electrical model of the distribution grid (power flow, feeder and transformer constraints) as well as battery degradation and market or pricing mechanisms are beyond its scope and left to future work.

1.1 Motivation

Urban charging demand is highly uneven across time and location, which can cause queues at popular stations while other sites remain virtually unused. At the same time, cars that are parked for extended periods of time (in residential or commercial areas) can remain plugged in, creating opportunities for bidirectional energy exchange. This means that the spatial distribution of charging stations can have a significant impact on both user experience and grid load. For example, placing stations in high-traffic areas may improve accessibility but could also lead to congestion and increased waiting times. Conversely, locating stations in less busy areas might reduce queues but could limit their utilization and the potential for vehicle-to-grid (V2G) services. Understanding the spatial and temporal patterns of charging demand is therefore crucial for effective infrastructure planning. However, there is a lack of open, reproducible methods for assessing candidate locations based on real-world mobility patterns and grid constraints.

1.2 Problem Statement

Given the aforementioned challenges, the problem statement of this paper can be formulated as follows: How can we determine the optimal spatial distribution of bidirectional charging stations, while regarding existing charging stations, in an urban area by integrating traffic

simulation data with partially synthetic grid constraints, in order to maximize accessibility and minimize waiting times for electric vehicle users?

1.3 Contributions

This paper contributes a practical and reproducible workflow for planning bidirectional charging infrastructure with coupled traffic and grid evaluation. This work contains a user interface for deterministic scenario-based traffic generation along with a thorough analysis of candidate station portfolios under varying demand and grid conditions. By integrating synthetic grid constraints with mobility-based accessibility metrics, we provide a holistic framework for siting decisions that can be adapted to different urban contexts and policy objectives.

The main contributions of this work are as follows:

- A simulation-based siting pipeline that jointly evaluates mobility accessibility and distribution-grid impact.
- A multi-criteria scoring framework for comparing candidate station portfolios under proto-realistic demand variability.
- A reference implementation in Python to support reproducible experiments and scenario-based sensitivity studies.
- A reality-based implementation of synthetic wallbox profiles, for which no real-world data is currently available.
- A fully working pipeline for independent scenario generation, traffic simulation, and evaluation of candidate station portfolios, which can be adapted to different urban contexts.
- A user interface for scenario-based traffic generation and evaluation of candidate station portfolios, enabling stakeholders to adjust parameters and visualize the impact of different siting strategies.

2. Related Work

Planning charging infrastructure has been studied extensively, and recent reviews organize the field along the dimensions of station siting, sizing, grid reinforcement, trip-considerations and the treatment of uncertainty [5, 13]. Most contributions optimize either where demand is best served or how the grid copes with the additional load; bidirectional charging, in which vehicles also feed power back, is only beginning to be integrated into such planning frameworks [9].

2.1 Traffic-Aware Siting

Traffic-aware siting methods estimate charging demand from origin-destination flows, activity patterns, and route choices, often placing stations so as to maximize coverage of traffic along routes. Data-driven analyses suggest that charging demand is largely shaped by proximity to amenities, EV density, and adjacency to high-traffic corridors, which motivates deriving demand from land-use data as we do [6]. Microscopic traffic simulators are increasingly used for this purpose: SUMO in particular provides built-in energy and charging-infrastructure models and has been used to assign electric vehicles to charging stations from simulated traffic data [7, 8].

A different approach than SUMO, is a mesoscopic traffic simulation model that uses a network of nodes and links to represent the road network, and simulates traffic flow based on traffic demand and road capacity. This approach can be used to estimate charging demand at a more aggregated level, and can be useful for planning charging infrastructure in areas with limited data availability or where detailed traffic simulation is not feasible. MATSim is an example of a mesoscopic traffic simulation model that has been used for this purpose, and paired with BEAM it is possible to simulate the impact of charging infrastructure on a dynamic traffic network [11, 12].

2.2 Grid-Aware Siting

Grid-aware planning approaches prioritize feeder hosting capacity, voltage stability, and peak-load mitigation, frequently relying on metaheuristic optimization to jointly site and size stations under electrical constraints [5]. While they improve technical feasibility, they can yield a poor user experience when travel behavior is not modeled in sufficient detail. The placement of charging stations is often motivated not only by charging demand and by economic advantages, but also by repercussions for the electrical network [14]. While a reasonable amount of studies have been conducted on the siting of charging stations, there are only few that consider working with large-scale electric vehicle charging infrastructure [15].

2.3 Coupled and Bidirectional Approaches

A smaller but growing body of work couples transportation simulation with power-system analysis, for example through co-simulation frameworks that pass simulated charging loads to a distribution-grid model [10]. For bidirectional charging, planning models increasingly distinguish public and private chargers and account for uncertainty in demand and renewable generation [9]. Integrated and openly reproducible frameworks that combine microscopic mobility simulation with bidirectional charging at the level of individual public stations and private home wallboxes, however, remain limited. This paper addresses that gap on the mobility-and-demand side, while leaving a detailed electrical model of the distribution grid to future work.

3. Methodology

Initially our approach involved MATSim for its high degree of configurability and its ability to simulate large-scale traffic networks, and when researching for a way increase the realism of our simulation, we incorporated BEAM (fig. 1) – which is an extension of MATSim. The pipeline begins with fetching data from OpenStreetMap,

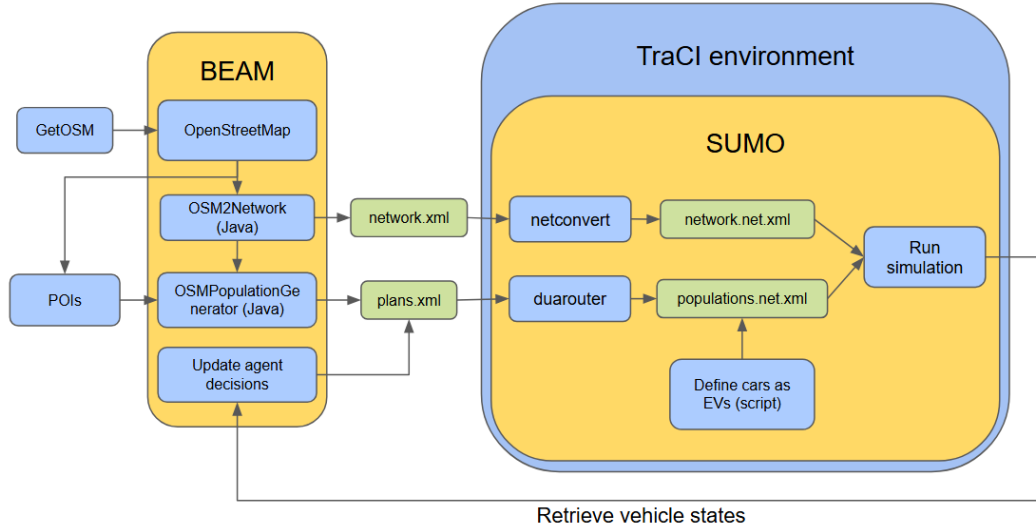


Figure 1: Data Pipeline under BEAM and MATSim.

which is then processed and converted into a MATSim-compatible format. BEAM, which allows for real-time manipulation, is then used to simulate traffic flows and charging behavior. However, we found its lack of deterministic execution, high error rates, and the need for extensive calibration to be a barrier to productivity and reproducibility. We therefore switched to SUMO and TraCI completely, which provides a more stable and deterministic simulation environment, while still allowing for detailed and dynamic modeling of traffic flows and charging behavior.

As of now, we are using SUMO as a microscopic traffic simulator and TraCI with a grid impact model and a statistical distribution for home-charging devices to evaluate the spatial distribution of bidirectional charging stations. Two algorithms are implemented to test different siting strategies:

- **Saturate-and-Prune:** A naive iterative approach where candidate locations cover all road segments, ensuring maximum accessibility. After each trial execution, charging stations with less than a 5% utilization rate are removed, and the simulation is rerun until all remaining stations exceed this threshold.
- **Clustering:** A heuristic that prioritizes locations with high traffic flow, potential

traffic congestions and consideration for low state of charge. The flow of traffic determines the placement of charging stations, with the goal of maximizing accessibility in spots where vehicles are most likely to need charging and decreasing the likelihood of detours.

3.1 System Overview

4. Experiments

4.1 Experimental Setup

4.2 Datasets

4.3 Evaluation Metrics

4.4 Results

5. Discussion

5.1 Interpretation of Results

5.2 Limitations

6. Conclusion

This paper presented a simulation-driven method for distributing bidirectional charging stations under joint traffic and grid criteria. The evaluation demonstrates that coordinated planning can improve both charging accessibility and electrical reliability.

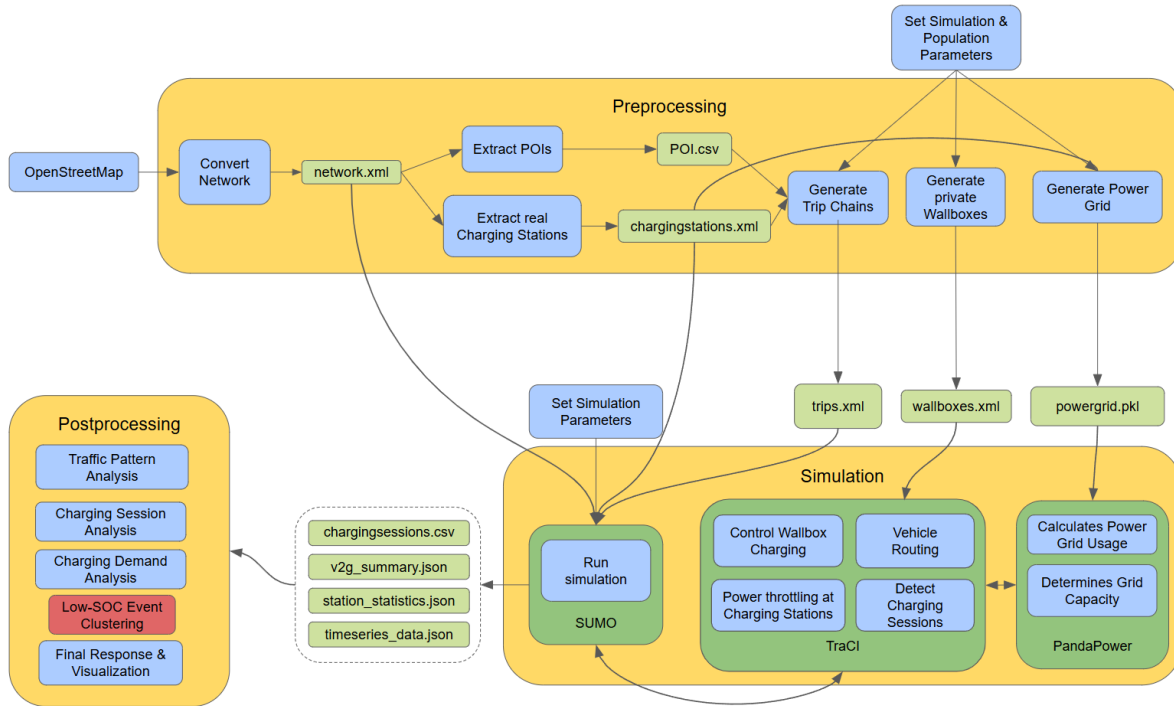


Figure 2: Complete Data Pipeline

6.1 Future Work

Future work will include stochastic optimization under forecast uncertainty and integration of dynamic pricing signals. We also plan to validate the framework with larger real-world datasets and pilot deployments in mixed urban-suburban regions.

Acknowledgments

The authors thank the Fraunhofer Center of Application KEIM for supporting this research work.

References

- [1] International Energy Agency (IEA), *Global EV Outlook 2023: Catching up with Climate Ambitions*. Paris, France: IEA, 2023. [Online]. Available: <https://www.iea.org/reports/global-ev-outlook-2023>
- [2] W. Kempton and J. Tomić, “Vehicle-to-grid power fundamentals: Calculating capacity and net revenue,” *Journal of Power Sources*, vol. 144, no. 1, pp. 268–279, 2005.
- [3] K. Clement-Nyns, E. Haesen, and J. Driesen, “The impact of charging plug-in hybrid electric vehicles on a residential distribution grid,” *IEEE Transactions on Power Systems*, vol. 25, no. 1, pp. 371–380, 2010.
- [4] F. He, D. Wu, Y. Yin, and Y. Guan, “Optimal deployment of public charging stations for plug-in hybrid electric vehicles,” *Transportation Research Part B: Methodological*, vol. 47, pp. 87–101, 2013.
- [5] “A review on electric vehicle charging station planning: Infrastructure placement, sizing, upgrades, and uncertainties,” *Journal of Energy Storage*, 2025. [Online]. Available: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S2352152X25040381>
- [6] “Data-driven optimization of EV charging station placement using causal discovery,” *arXiv preprint arXiv:2503.17055*, 2025. [Online]. Available: <https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.17055>

- [7] T. Kurczveil, P. Á. López, and E. Schnieder, "Implementation of an energy model and a charging infrastructure in SUMO," in *Simulation of Urban Mobility (SUMO)*, https://www.researchgate.net/publication/276063158_Implementation_of_an_Energy_Model_and_a_Charging_Infrastructure_in_SUMO,
- [8] "Assignment approach for electric vehicle charging using traffic data collected by SUMO," *World Electric Vehicle Journal*, vol. 14, no. 2, art. 40, 2023. [Online]. Available: <https://www.mdpi.com/2032-6653/14/2/40>
- [9] "Vehicle-to-grid enabled charging infrastructure planning and operations considering demand uncertainties," *Transportation Research Part D: Transport and Environment*, 2023. [Online]. Available: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S1361920923003152>
- [10] "Assessing EV charging impacts on power distribution systems: A unified co-simulation framework," *arXiv preprint arXiv:2505.21773*, 2025. [Online]. Available: <https://arxiv.org/abs/2505.21773>
- [11] A. Horni, K. Nagel, and K. W. Axhausen, Eds., *The Multi-Agent Transport Simulation MATSim*. London, U.K.: Ubiquity Press, 2016. [Online]. Available: <https://doi.org/10.5334/baw>
- [12] C. Sheppard, R. Waraich, A. Campbell, A. Gopal, and A. Pozdnukhov, "Modeling plug-in electric vehicle charging demand with BEAM: The framework for behavior, energy, autonomy, and mobility," Lawrence Berkeley National Laboratory, Berkeley, CA, USA, Tech. Rep. LBNL-2001018, 2017. [Online]. Available: <https://www.osti.gov/biblio/1398472>
- [13] R. Pagany, L. Ramirez Camargo, and W. Dorner, "A review of spatial localization methodologies for the electric vehicle charging infrastructure," *International Journal of Sustainable Transportation*, vol. 13, no. 6, pp. 433–449, 2019. [Online]. Available: <https://doi.org/10.1080/15568318.2018.1481243>
- [14] F. Ahmad, A. Iqbal, I. Ashraf, M. Marzband, and I. Khan, "Optimal location of electric vehicle charging station and its impact on distribution network: A review," *Energy Reports*, vol. 8, pp. 2314–2333, 2022. [Online]. Available: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S2352484722001809>
- [15] "Large-scale optimization of electric vehicle charging infrastructure," in *Proc. 32nd ACM Int. Conf. on Advances in Geographic Information Systems (SIGSPATIAL '24)*, 2024. [Online]. Available: <https://dl.acm.org/doi/10.1145/3678717.3700830>
- [16] V. Lazari and A. Chassiakos, "Multi-objective optimization of electric vehicle charging station deployment using genetic algorithms," *Applied Sciences*, vol. 13, no. 8, art. 4867, 2023. [Online]. Available: <https://www.mdpi.com/2076-3417/13/8/4867>